

Ravi Sreedharan

Ravi Sreedharan is the Co-founder and President of the Indian School of Development Management (ISDM), India's first management institution dedicated entirely to the social sector. After 24 years in global banking, he moved to the social sector in 2011 and co-founded ISDM in 2016 to build Development Management as a discipline in its own right.

Education

- MBA, Indian Institute of Management Ahmedabad
- B.Tech. in Mechanical Engineering, Indian Institute of Technology (BHU)

Career

Spent 24 years in the corporate sector, most of it at HSBC, working across 30+ countries. Held senior roles including Regional Marketing Head for the Middle East and Africa, Head of Consumer Products for Asia Pacific, and Consumer Banking Head for Indonesia. Rose to CEO and President Director of Bank Ekonomi, an Indonesian bank acquired by HSBC.

In 2011, at 49, left the bank CEO role to join the Azim Premji Foundation as Head of Education Leadership & Management, focused on strengthening leadership and management capacity within India's education system.

In 2016, co-founded ISDM with three other founders. Teaches Introduction to Development Management at ISDM.

Voice in the Sector

- TEDx speaker on "Management for Development," making the case that India's social sector lacks the management capability its ambitions need
- Champion of fair pay and talent management in the sector; ISDM benchmarks compensation and practices across 14 archetypes of social purpose organisations
- Contributor to India Development Review on what businesses can learn from the social sector

Building the Discipline

- ISDM's Knowledge and Research Centre is building a Body of Knowledge on Development Management, distinct from business management and public administration
- ISDM reports that its curriculum standards for Development Management are now mirrored by peer institutions
- ISDM's impact assessment finds that 1 in 3 alumni lead work reaching 25,000+ beneficiaries every year
- ISDM is building its own campus in Greater Noida as it marks a decade since its founding



Ravi Sreedharan's Story

Ravi saw a gap in how India's social sector was run: business had business management and the State had public administration, but the social sector had no dedicated discipline of professional management. In his words, social sector organisations are often "over-led and under-managed." Before founding ISDM, he and his co-founders spoke with more than a thousand senior leaders and institutions across continents.

Leadership at ISDM

As President, Ravi has built ISDM around the flagship 11-month Post Graduate Program in Development Management (PGP-DM), running since 2017, with 400+ alumni now leading programmes and organisations across India. Its pedagogy rests on knowing, doing and being.

ISDM has grown beyond the PGP-DM into practitioner programmes in Results-Based Program Management, SPO Governance & Compliance, and Women on Boards. It also convenes the sector through the Dialogues on Development Management, which has run three editions since 2023 with 1,200 participants and 80+ speakers. He argues that funders can bridge the gap with grassroots organisations, and that fair pay is essential to building talent.

He is now putting succession and a governance structure in place so that ISDM outlives its founders.

His philosophy: the social sector deserves management built for its own complexity, not borrowed from business.